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|  <b>VERNON AND DISTRICT ASSOCIATION<br/>FOR COMMUNITY LIVING</b>                                                                                                                                                                              | SECTION: 6 – WORKFORCE           |                                                            | NO: 6.3.6 |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | ISSUED DATE:<br>October 15, 2004 | REVISION DATE:<br><del>August 22, 2017</del><br>March 2026 |           |
| <b><i>SUBJECT: CONFLICT RESOLUTION</i></b><br>PAGE: 1 of 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                  |                                                            |           |
| <b>POLICY:</b> VDACL is committed to maintaining open, respectful, and effective communication. Employees, Program Coordinators, and Management are expected to make every reasonable effort to resolve concerns, conflicts, and disputes in a timely and professional manner by following established lines of communication. |                                  |                                                            |           |

## DEFINITIONS:

Conflict in the workplace will arise due to factors including poor communication, limited resources, different values or interests, poor or unequal performance among peers, and personality clashes.

Conflict in the policy *does not include*:

- Workplace violence and harassment, which should be addressed according to policy 6.3.12 Workplace Violence and Harassment.
- Breaches of VDACL policies or procedures. These situations should be reported according to established reporting structure according to policy 6.3.8 Lines of Communication.

**SCOPE:** Applies to all employees and volunteers of VDACL

## PURPOSE:

- 1) Support respectful, timely, and fair resolution of concerns, conflicts, and disputes
- 2) Enhance the quality, integrity, and effectiveness of the Association's services
- 3) Ensure compliance with applicable collective agreements and employment standards
- 4) Manage minor conflicts to prevent escalation

## PROCEDURE:

- 1) Employees should address their own conflicts quickly and informally by politely and privately raising the issue directly with the other involved person.
- 2) All conflicts must be approached with respect for the other involved employee, coworkers, and VDACL respectful workplace policies and standards.
- 3) When resolving conflicts informally, employees should:
  - Communicate in person
  - Use active listening techniques to improve understanding and reduce miscommunication
  - Recognize that conflict may be perceived differently by different people

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- Only address one conflict at a time, working to resolve one before discussing another
  - Validate each other's experiences and feelings
  - Avoid attempting to determine who is "right" and who is "wrong"
  - Brainstorm possible solutions, mutually decide on the most effective resolution, and work together using the decided strategy to resolve the conflict.
- 4) All employees shall be given every reasonable opportunity to present their understanding of a situation and propose solutions.
- 5) Certain situations should be reported directly to the PC, including:
- Informal conflict resolution that has been attempted but has not been successful.
  - Where informal resolution may be ineffective (such as where a conflict involves a sensitive topic or there is a significant seniority difference).
  - Concerns involving breaches of Association policy and procedures.
- 6) Upon receiving a report of conflict, the PC will determine the issue and what resolution the individual wishes to achieve, and considers if the issue is conflict under this policy or whether it needs to be addressed under another policy (such as Conduct and Behaviour, Workplace Violence and Harassment).
- 7) When appropriate, PC will encourage, redirect, and support employees to resolve conflict informally following Procedures above.
- 8) If informal resolution does not occur after the conflict is reported, facilitated mediation by the Director of Employee Relations or designate may be offered as a method of conflict resolution.
- Both parties will meet and present their concerns and will be assisted to understand the other's perspectives and develop possible solutions to the conflict, or where no resolution can be reached, employees are assisted to negotiate and accept a reasonable solution that they can both accept.
  - Mediation in this manner will be documented, including the key issues, resolution agreed to, and next steps, and this documentation is used for reference only.
  - Where conflict remains unresolved, and the employees are not breaching any company policy, the mediator will set expectations for working professionally together moving forward, to ensure escalation or other workplace concerns do not occur.
- 9) Employees must engage in conflict resolution in good faith, with the goal of fostering a positive working environment, and when solutions to a conflict are agreed to, employees must implement the solution to the best of their abilities.

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- 10) When solutions can't be found, employees must abide by all company policies and expectations in their interactions with other involved employees. Employees who escalate conflicts to the point of breaching company policy, or who fail to meet the requirements of their position due to conflict, may be subject to disciplinary action up to and including termination.
- 11) If concerns remain unresolved, the employee may contact their local Union Shop Steward in accordance with the Community Living Services Collective Agreement.
- 12) PCs are responsible for promoting a workplace that recognizes and addresses conflicts quickly and effectively, and are required to communicate the procedures and expectations outlined in this policy and assign Conflict Resolution training as necessary.
- 13) Employees with concerns involving a PC, Management, or Executive Management, shall address the concern directly with the person involved. If the conflict remains unresolved or addressing concerns directly would be inappropriate, the employee may involve the Director of Employee Relations and/or their Union Representative, in accordance with the Collective Agreement.
- 14) It is a breach of this policy to report conflict falsely, frivolously, or with an intention to waste company resources or harm another employee, and employees may be subject to progressive discipline up to and including termination.
- 15) Confidentiality will be maintained to the greatest extent possible. Employees must not discuss workplace conflicts with other staff.
- 16) The current Collective Agreement shall be adhered to at all times.